

Everywhere here can say this: The English locative impersonal

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For many speakers of English, the locative expression *everywhere* can be used instead of the universal indefinite pronoun *everyone* in certain contexts, denoting a generic or impersonal set of individuals. The current paper documents this “impersonal *everywhere*” for the first time, applying a range of syntactic tests to determine its synchronic status. Based on a large-scale acceptability study, we find that the impersonal requires reference to a large location, as in *everywhere on the coast*. The results further indicate that UK speakers might be more accepting of it than US speakers, in particular younger UK speakers. We discuss the grammatical properties of this construction and outline how it might have arisen from variationist and diachronic perspectives, raising a range of questions for future study on this understudied construction.¹

Keywords: impersonals, locatives, innovation, restrictor, metonymy

1 INTRODUCTION

This study reports on an as-yet undocumented construction in English, in which quantified locative indefinite forms like *everywhere* are used as impersonal subjects: (1) means that broadly everyone on the coast eats fish and chips. This usage contrasts with a metonymic “institutional” use of *everywhere* already available in English, as in (2). This difference appears to reflect two metonymic tendencies known to affect specific nouns of place: LOCATION → INSTITUTION, and LOCATION → INHABITANTS (see [Radden and Kövecses 1999](#)).

- (1) Everywhere [= everyone] on the coast eats fish and chips.
- (2) (a) Everywhere [= every shop] takes credit cards these days.

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- (b) Everywhere [= every shop] will fillet their fish for you, if you ask them.
- (c) Linguistics was once a rare subject in English higher education, but pretty much everywhere [= every university] in England has a linguistics department these days.

As we explain in what follows, the impersonal (1) is more acceptable with a geographic description following *everywhere*, in this case *on the coast*. We call this a *restrictor*, as it delineates the domain in which *everywhere* is understood. Utterances like (1) but without a restrictor are degraded, if not completely unacceptable:

- (3) ?? Everywhere eats fish and chips.

In this paper, we document this construction for the first time based on a large-scale acceptability study and explore the basic grammatical properties of this “impersonal *everywhere*”. We also provide a first characterization of how different age groups use it in the UK and North America, and how differences between both samples are relevant in a language-change scenario.

We focus on establishing three main empirical findings for what can be called “impersonal”, “generic” or “individual” *everywhere*: first, language users show a strong preference for an overt locative PP restrictor referring to a large location for *everywhere* to be acceptable. Secondly, although this construction can be found beyond British English, UK speakers in our sample show higher acceptability of the construction than those in North America. And third, younger speakers are more accepting of the impersonal usage in the UK sample, suggestive of an incipient change in progress.

The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 presents a general overview of the phenomenon as we currently understand it. Section 3 tests the key elements of the phenomenon in a large-scale acceptability study. In Section 4, we briefly discuss the findings from both an empirical and variationist perspective, before moving on to consider the data from a diachronic perspective in Section 5. Section 6 concludes. We highlight what we consider the most important outstanding questions throughout, acknowledging that we cannot address any of these individual topics fully within the scope of the current paper.

2 IMPERSONAL EVERYWHERE

As is well known, *everywhere*, meaning ‘every place’, functions both as a locative adverb (4a) and as a nominal quantified indefinite locative noun (4b), akin to other quantified indefinite pronouns in English, e.g. *everyone*, *everything*, *someone*, *something*, *somewhere*.

- (4) (a) We looked everywhere [= in every place] for the keys.
- (b) Everywhere [= every place] in the Lake District is beautiful.

This study provides the first description of *everywhere* (or rather [Quantifier + *where*]) in a nominal usage as an impersonal subject meaning *everyone*. This use appears primarily when *everywhere* is modified by a following PP *restrictor*; the PP restricts the domain of quantification introduced by *every*, an otherwise universal quantifier.² This usage is

²For additional background on domain restriction and quantification, see e.g. Von Stechow (1994) or Stanley and Szabo (2000).

most typical of colloquial language and appears very sparingly in written sources such as corpora.³ Nevertheless, examples can be found online and in the media. The instances in (5)–(7) come from several different English varieties: chiefly British and North American Englishes, but with a few hits in Nigerian English.⁴ We take these examples to be representative of typical use and general geographic spread.

(5) **British English:**

- (a) Everywhere in England knows what Cottage Pie is. [based on an anonymized tweet]⁵
- (b) So everywhere in the UK is saying it's raining. [based on an anonymized tweet]
- (c) Everywhere in England was brought up to dislike Liverpool fans. [based on an anonymized tweet]
- (d) I think a lot of it's just a whole, **everywhere** is discontent at the moment. [BNC, KCP SP:PS0GS]⁶

(6) **American English:**

- (a) The fact that everywhere in America thinks it's acceptable to keep the thermostat on 68 is UNACCEPTABLE! [public tweet]
- (b) Everywhere on the internet is talking about how you should be better ... [NOW corpus]⁷
- (c) We are feeling the same thing that everywhere in the state is feeling... [NOW corpus]
- (d) Everywhere in the world wants the same and that's why they all want to come to America. [COCA]

(7) **Nigerian English:**

- (a) Everywhere in the country has been gaslighted. [NOW corpus]⁸

³Corpus queries used in NOW (Davies 2016) and COCA (Davies 2008) were: *everywhere* PREP ART NOUN+ '_v?z _v?g, *everywhere* PREP NOUN+ '_v?z _v?g, *everywhere* PREP ART NOUN+ '_v?z, *everywhere* PREP NOUN+ '_v?z. A query of GloWbE (Davies 2013) for *everywhere* PREP NOUN VERB returns no instances of the target construction. We take this to reflect the register profile of that corpus rather than the absence of the phenomenon: GloWbE draws primarily on edited web text, whereas impersonal *everywhere* appears to be characteristic of spontaneous informal speech and social media registers. A corpus matched to this register profile would be required for reliable frequency estimates, which we leave to future work.

⁴An anonymous reviewer asks whether we include Nigerian English because we cannot find the phenomenon elsewhere. This is not the case: we include it because English is a pluricentric language. English in Nigeria has over 100 million L1 and L2 speakers, functions as an official lingua franca, and is undergoing an ongoing nativization process (Kachru 1992, Mesthrie 2010). Were impersonal *everywhere* attested only in Nigerian English, one might ask whether the usage were idiosyncratic to that variety; but as the British and American examples demonstrate, it is not.

⁵Similar examples can be found on social media but will not be reproduced here due to issues of informed consent (Fiesler and Proferes 2018).

⁶This rare example from the BNC is exceptional in that it does not have a PP restrictor. We suspect that it may, in fact, be a metonymic institutional use, yet the psychological predicate is striking.

⁷<https://www.wral.com/nc-s-new-988-mental-health-hotline-sees-22-year-to-year-increase-compared-to-old-1-800-number/20561300/>

⁸<https://tribuneonlineng.com/2023-buhari-apc-run-nigeria-aground-says-hayatu-deen/>

Universal *every* is not the only possible quantifier in this construction. Existential *some* is attested in (8), with a relative clause restrictor. It is clear that the subject is human rather than an institution since it binds *they* and is the subject of the psychological predicate *believe*. We explore relative clause restrictors in Section 2.6, bound *they* in Section 2.7 and psych-verbs in Section 3.5.5.

(8) Question: “Where is she going?”

Answer: “Somewhere, that believes they deserve her.”

[Ted Lasso, Season 3 Episode 6, 4:00 mins]

The relative paucity of written examples in corpora suggests that those who employ the construction do so primarily in informal spoken registers. Indeed, we became aware of impersonal *everywhere* via interactions in casual spoken English. Notably, many consultants appeared to be unaware that they possessed the construction until it was pointed out to them. Social media examples on Twitter (now known as X), which can be found primarily for British but also American English, reflect more readily spontaneous informal spoken registers.⁹ Given that we have good evidence for the existence of an impersonal *everywhere* construction, regardless of sparse corpus data, this study relies on a mix of introspection and consultant judgments followed by a large confirmatory experiment.

2.1 The structural precedent for locative subjects in English

The emergence of locative impersonal *everywhere* must be contextualised within the broader grammar of English, which has historically been quite permissive in allowing unusual fillers for its syntactic subject slot (see Bresnan 1994 and Sluckin 2021 for different aspects of non-canonical subjects). English already possesses a range of constructions where locative elements exhibit subject-like properties. Familiar examples include Locative Inversion (e.g., *Out of the cave came a mountain lion*), the ‘swarm’ alternation (e.g., *The garden was swarming with bees*), and constructions of the *under the mat is dirty* type (Bresnan 1994).

However, while these existing patterns demonstrate that English tolerates locatives in preverbal subject positions, the impersonal *everywhere* construction represents a genuine grammatical innovation. In Locative Inversion or expletive *there* constructions, the apparent locative subject appears early in the clause, but the true semantic subject is present later as an associate. Impersonal *everywhere* is exceptional because it fulfills both the syntactic and semantic subject roles simultaneously, quantifying directly over a generic set of individuals.

2.2 Disambiguating impersonal and institutional interpretations

In the INSTITUTIONAL use of *everywhere*, introduced in (1)–(2), *where* stands in metonymically for a non-human noun which does need not be inherently locative, e.g. shop, university, local authority. This kind of metonymy, i.e. a process by which “one conceptual entity is mentally accessed via another entity” (Radden and Kövecses 1999:336), is not

⁹Recent limitations on API access to X/Twitter data and the non-tagged nature of tweets means that it is no longer possible to effectively isolate or quantitatively analyze all instances of impersonal *everywhere* on Twitter/X.

particularly exceptional; the institutional use of *everywhere* reflects a wider sub-type of metonymy whereby places can stand in for institutions (Radden and Kövecses 1999, Littlemore 2017), e.g. employing *Whitehall* or *Washington* for the British or American governments respectively. We note that a characteristic of this institutional use appears to be that it does not rely on modification via a PP to be grammatical, i.e. restriction via PP modification is an optional addendum. This usage is similar to another well-documented sub-type of metonymic coercion: LOCATION-NP $\rightarrow$ INDIVIDUALS, by which places may stand in for inhabitants (Radden and Kövecses 1999, Littlemore 2017), e.g. *London* [= *London's inhabitants*] *drinks more than Edinburgh* [= *Edinburgh's inhabitants*].

In contrast, the IMPERSONAL use of *everywhere* differs from the institutional use because it quantifies over generic individuals in particular locations (which are defined and limited by the domain-restricting PP), whereas the institutional use does not. Metonymic use of place names behaves more like institutional *everywhere* and differently to impersonal *everywhere*.

Therefore, in defining the semantic contribution of the locative impersonal *everywhere*, we classify its individual reading as ‘generic’ rather than ‘arbitrary’. In the formal literature on impersonal pronouns, these terms denote distinct quantificational forces: a ‘generic’ reading corresponds to a quasi-universal quantification over individuals (akin to *everyone* or *people*), whereas an ‘arbitrary’ reading corresponds to a quasi-existential interpretation in episodic contexts (akin to *someone* or a non-specific *they*); see Cinque (1988), Egerland (2003). Because the locative impersonal *everywhere* functions as a universal quantifier over a set of individuals within a restricted domain, it aligns exclusively with the quasi-universal, generic interpretation. Consequently, we adopt the term ‘generic individual reading’ to accurately reflect its semantics and avoid the quasi-existential implications of ‘arbitrary’ (see also Carlson and Pelletier 1995 for foundational discussion of genericity). However, where alternative locative impersonals are present, e.g. *somewhere* or *nowhere*, a generic reading cannot be present by default, as these items are inherently associated with existential and negative quantification, respectively. This observation leads to the prediction that differently quantified versions of an indefinite [Q+where], may behave differently with respect to their aspectual and temporal behaviour; this falls beyond the scope of the current investigation, yet should inform future work on the topic.

2.3 PP Restriction and impersonal meaning

Impersonal *everywhere* requires an overt restrictor, whereas PP-modification in the institutional use is optional. Consider the canonical personal universal indefinite pronoun (label following Quirk et al. 1985) *everyone* in (9). Individuals typically disapprove of actions, whereas institutions forbid them. Substituting *everywhere* for *everyone* in (10) demonstrates the effect of the restrictor: (10a) permits an individual (‘every person’) reading precisely because of the licensing PP *in England*.

- (9) (a) Everyone in England disapproves of public displays of affection.
- (b) ?? Everyone in England forbids public displays of affection.
- (10) (a) Everywhere in England disapproves of public displays of affection. [individual/institution]
- (b) Everywhere in England forbids public displays of affection. [institution]

Omitting the restrictor in a potentially ambiguous sentence like (10a) eliminates the impersonal reading, isolating the institutional interpretation, as shown in (11).

- (11) (a) Everywhere disapproves of public displays of affection. [institution]
 (b) Everywhere forbids public displays of affection. [institution]

This structural dependency generates one of the hypotheses tested in Section 3: speakers require an overt restrictor to license the impersonal *everywhere* construction.

The mechanism driving this restriction parallels the impersonal use of the third-person plural pronoun *they*. Brody (2013) observes that English locative PPs can introduce a silent, semantically active person argument. This structural mechanism licenses the universal impersonal reading of *they*. In (12a), the locative PP supplies a covert [PEOPLE] antecedent. Without the locative, the impersonal reading fails (12b).

- (12) (a) In Italy they [= people] like to take a nap in the afternoon.
 (b) # They like to take a nap in the afternoon.

Assuming locatives can inherently introduce a non-specific argument in the semantics (see also Alexiadou and Carvalho 2017), this theoretical premise provides the formal licensing mechanism for impersonal *everywhere*. To obtain a generic human subject reading, *everywhere* strictly requires the combination of the universal quantifier and an overt locative restrictor to supply this covert [PEOPLE] argument under a generic reading; thus, the spatial pronoun is functionally coerced into a generic individual subject.

In sharp contrast, institutional *everywhere* does not require overt PP-modification; the institutional reading remains intact without a restrictor (11b). We hypothesize that institutional *everywhere* functions independently of structural PP licensing because its *wh*-component *where* operates as contextually d-linked (Pesetsky 1987), establishing familiarity. Under a situation semantics framework (Kratzer 2019), an implicit Austinian topic situation licenses this d-linking; the external discourse context or predicate entailments resolve the institutional referent.

Consequently, institutional *everywhere* is felicitous only when a situational domain is reconstructable. Acceptable sentences provide a topic situation via contextual association or predicate entailment, whereas (13c) lacks both.

- (13) (a) Everywhere takes credit cards = predicate entails shops/businesses etc.
 (b) In the build-up to the war, everywhere built air-raid shelters = context entails public authorities/governments
 (c) #/*Everywhere loves a shower = no reconstructable situation topic in context or an entailment of the predicate.

While an independent investigation of the pragmatic constraints on institutional *everywhere* falls outside the scope of this paper, the contrast is definitional: impersonal *everywhere* relies on structural licensing via a PP, whereas institutional *everywhere* relies on situational d-linking.

2.4 Restrictor size

Both standard *they* (Brody 2013) and impersonal *everywhere* are odd if the PP does not refer to a geographical location, (14)–(15).

- (14) (a) Everywhere in Italy likes to take a nap in the afternoon.
 (b) # Everywhere in Italian restaurants likes to take a nap in the afternoon.
- (15) (a) In Italy they like to take a nap in the afternoon.
 (b) # In Italian restaurants they like to take a nap in the afternoon.

The impersonal use of *they* is more sensitive to conventionalized associations with the predicate, while *everywhere* is more strictly associated with larger geographical domains. For example, it is strange to nap in an Italian restaurant, (15b), but making pasta is perfectly expected, (16a); in the latter context *they* is felicitous, yet impersonal *everywhere* is not, (16b).

- (16) (a) # Everywhere in Italian restaurants makes pasta properly.
 (b) In Italian restaurants they make pasta properly.

We generalize that small and/or non-geographic locations are generally infelicitous with impersonal *everywhere*, (17a), while large locative restrictors like *in the county/state/country* or known large cities comprising many boroughs such as London or New York are felicitous, (17b).

- (17) (a) * Everywhere in the background/room/pub was celebrating.
 (b) Everywhere in London/Yorkshire/Scotland/the world was celebrating.

The fact that the impersonal reading of *everywhere* seems to require a “large” location may be synchronically or diachronically related to the metonymy of places as individuals, which tends to denote inhabitants (Radden and Kövecses 1999, Littlemore 2017). While large locations can have inhabitants, small places like rooms or pubs do not host a subvisible population.

While it is clear that some relation holds with established patterns of metonymy, we leave detailed formal syntactic and semantic analysis of the construction as a whole for further work until we have a better understanding of the restrictor; our study tested the need for a restrictor, but did not include different types of restrictor. In any case, the “large” restrictor appears necessary to induce a type of sort-shifting from location to (a group of) individuals, as opposed from location to institution (see work on sorts by Dölling 1992 and on sort shifting and metonymy by Borschev and Partee 2001). If the processes involved in producing impersonal *everywhere* have in fact gone beyond a synchronic metonymy, i.e., if it is developing or has developed into a stand-alone construction of its own, then any synchronic sort-shifting will have translated into a grammaticalized construction with a novel selection constraint.

2.5 Subjecthood and objecthood

Our next comparison of institutional and individual *everywhere* indicates that only the former can function as a simple direct object.

In (18) the available reading is of retailers, although in this case restriction from a relative clause strongly improves the acceptability of the sentence.

- (18) The wholesalers sold their excess stock to everywhere/anywhere ?(that would take it).

Similarly, institutional *everywhere* seems to work better with a *by*-phrase, (19). Modification by a PP once again improves the sentence slightly.

- (19) Credit Cards are accepted by everywhere ?(with a card machine) these days.

Turning to individual *everywhere*, we see first additional evidence that it can function as a subject, be it in simple transitive clauses (20) or with a psychological predicate (21).

- (20) (a) Everywhere [= people] on the coast eats Fish'n'Chips.
(b) Everywhere in Scotland waits eagerly for Burns Night.

In object position, however, *everywhere* does not allow any individual reading; it can only be understood adverbially, (21).

- (21) (a) Vengeful sea monsters eat everywhere [*people/in all places] on the coast.
(b) ? William Wallis helped everywhere in Scotland.
(c) * King James VI greeted/met everywhere in Scotland.

An exception appears to be instances of Exceptional Case Marking (ECM) in which the object of the initial verb is simultaneously the subject of the second part of the clause and is as such permissible with an individual reading of *everywhere*:

- (22) Thanks to constant news coverage, the Queen watched **everywhere** in the UK enjoying (their) street parties for the Jubilee celebrations.

These examples indicate that *everywhere* must act as a syntactic subject in order to receive a generic individual reading. Yet there appear to be additional constraints on the type of subject. In passive clauses, impersonal *everywhere* is odd as the promoted subject, (23).

- (23) (a) ?? Everywhere in Wales was mistreated (by Westminster).
(b) ?? Everywhere in Britain was robbed (by the tax rise).
(c) ?? Everywhere in East Germany was investigated (by the Stasi).

Furthermore, (24a) shows that *everywhere* is degraded as the semantic but not syntactic subject in passives within a *by*-phrase. This is possibly due to a conflict between the semantics and the syntax of subjecthood which has been shown to be a non-unitary concept (Keenan 1976, McCloskey 1997). This constraint might not be particular to *everywhere*, since impersonal *one* is likewise unavailable in *by*-phrases, (24b).

- (24) (a) ?? Fish and Chips are eaten by everywhere in the UK.
(b) * Fish and Chips are eaten by *(every)one.

Lastly, there is some improvement of *everywhere* in a *by*-phrase with a psych-verb (24c), although it is still marked.

- (25) ? In the 1970's, Winston Churchill was revered by pretty much everywhere in Britain.

It is possible that the particularly degraded status of *everywhere* in passives as either the derived subject or in the *by*-phrase comes down to a syntactic and semantic disparity which prevents these derived subjects from acting simultaneously as both the logical and syntactic subjects, i.e. it is possible that *everywhere* must be the semantic and syntactic subject simultaneously. If *everywhere* cannot act as a direct object, from a syntactic perspective, it is unsurprising that it cannot become a derived subject; however, even as a derived syntactic subject, the semantic subject either remains implicit or is realised by the *by*-phrase. On the other hand, it may be the case that *everywhere* is degraded in a *by*-phrase because it does not act as the syntactic subject. While we are unsure as to exactly why *everywhere* in the *by*-phrase is potentially better with this psych-verb in a passive, (25) is also ambiguous if *everywhere* is to be understood institutionally or as impersonal denoting individuals. For this reason, we included passive and psych-verb conditions in the experimental portion of the study.

2.6 Restriction via relative clauses

In (8) we saw the example *Somewhere that believes they deserve her*, in which a relative *that*-clause restricts *everywhere* (rather than a PP). While such usage is judged by consultants as more marked than PP-modification, some particularities of restriction via relatives should be mentioned.

For canonical personal universal indefinite pronouns such as *everyone*, aside from being optional, a restrictor can take the form of a PP or a relative of the type [+human] *who* or *that* (26).¹⁰ However, *everywhere* resists *who*-relatives but is not ruled out with *that*-relatives:

- (26) (a) Everyone who knows Mary loves her.
 (b) * Everywhere who knows Mary loves her.
 (c) Everyone that knows Mary loves her.
 (d) ? Everywhere that knows Mary loves her.
- (27) (a) Everyone who's heard of Mother Teresa loves her.
 (b) * Everywhere who's heard of Mother Teresa loves her.
 (c) Everyone that's heard of Mother Teresa loves her.
 (d) ? Everywhere that's heard of Mother Teresa loves her.

The ungrammaticality of relative *who* may come down to the inability of an explicitly human syntactic relative element to be bound by a locative antecedent, indicating a syntax-semantics mismatch. Indeed, consider again Brody's (2013) suggestion that an impersonal semantic implicit [people] argument is induced by a locative PP before *they*; if such argumentation applies to impersonal *everywhere*, there is no [+human] syntactic element for *who* to agree with. However, it is an open question as to how *that* can, in lieu of a PP, restrict *everywhere* in such a way that an implicit generic [+human] reading can be elicited.

The *everywhere+that* phrases above are potentially ambiguous between an impersonal and institutional reading, as Mother Teresa could be the beneficiary of "institutional" or

¹⁰The judgements in this section are based on consultant judgements and are thus only indicative as we did not include the contrast between relative restrictors and geographic restriction in the experimental study.

individual love; the primary reading appears to be, however, institutional, i.e. ‘every corner of the globe/country that has heard of her’. Indeed, if we limit our discussion to predicates that are particularly strange on an institutional level, we see that an individual reading is also particularly strange or rather ungrammatical.

Consider a quantificational *that*-sentence such as (28a); with canonical *everyone*, it is acceptable, as is *everywhere* with a geographic PP restrictor (28b). However, attempting to use *everywhere* with a *that*-restrictor is ungrammatical (28c).

- (28) (a) Everyone that has a house looks after/loves their garden.
 (b) Everywhere in England looks after/loves their garden.
 (c) * Everywhere that has a house looks after/loves their garden.

That said, examples of *that*-restriction such as (29), which do not force an individual reading, are far more amenable to institutional readings than an impersonal interpretation and are less marked.

- (29) (a) Everywhere that has a queen adores her.
 (b) Everywhere that has a queen also has a king.

Finally, recall that in the previous subsection, we suggested that an impersonal reading of *everywhere* should not be available if *everyone* was not available. In this vein, we note the peculiarity of (30a) but the availability of (30b). Consultants commented that their interpretation was akin to the collective love of each country in a set of possible countries, i.e. institutional and not individual/impersonal. This reading probably arises because countries, rather than individuals, usually have royal families and queens.

- (30) (a) ? Everyone that has a royal family loves their queen.
 (b) Everywhere that has a royal family loves its/their queen. [Institutional]

In summary, preliminary evidence suggests that an individual reading is less readily available with *that*-restriction than with a geographic locative PP restrictor, if at all - a constraint that does not hold for institutional *everywhere*. The existence of attested examples with relative clauses for impersonal *everywhere* might then indicate an innovative exploratory use in the sense of Harris and Campbell (1995). In the experimental part of this study we focus solely on the effects of PP restrictors.

2.7 Bound pronouns

Further evidence that restricted *everywhere* can denote generic individuals comes from the choice of personal possessive pronoun bound by the impersonal subject, namely 3rd person *their*, which can be bound by non-referential/generic antecedents more widely. Such usage is frequent with indefinite pronouns (31a) containing quantifiers and quantified nouns (31b), both of which can be understood with what Fodor and Sag (1982) call *quantifier interpretation* as opposed to a *referential interpretation*.

- (31) (a) No one_i felt that they_i had been misled. (Huddleston and Pullum 2002:493)
 (b) Every student_i failed their_i exam(s).

Everywhere binds *they/their* as well:

- (32) (a) Everywhere in the world helps their family first and others second.
 (b) * Everywhere in the world helps its family first and others second.
 (c) * Everywhere in the world helps his/her family first and others second.

The sentence in (32a) delivers an unambiguous impersonal interpretation. The impersonal reading is ruled out in (32b) because individual countries cannot have families; the pronoun *it* is incompatible with the impersonal use due to its generally [−HUMAN] behaviour. We also see in (32c) that specific 3SG and [+HUMAN] pronouns *he/she* are also infelicitous on an impersonal reading. However, if the object of (32) were instead ‘neighbours’ as in (33a), the reading of *everywhere* would be more amenable to ambiguity with the institutional interpretation, since countries as institutions can be understood to have neighbours. With this altered predication, 3SG *its* is also felicitous as a bound pronoun under the institutional reading.

- (33) (a) Everywhere in the world helps their neighbours first and others second.
 [inst/imper.]
 (b) Everywhere in the world helps its neighbours first and others second.[inst]

In sum, 3SG pronouns such as *he/his*, *she/her*, *it/its* are ruled out in the impersonal use of *everywhere*, which must bind *they/their*. While *everywhere* references a particular place, the indefinite to which the pronoun refers remains non-referential on account of the universal quantifier. Thus, impersonal *everywhere* requires *they* in the same way that other indefinite pronouns (*everyone*, *everybody*, *somebody*, *nobody*) can bind 3PL. If impersonal *everywhere* is based either diachronically or synchronically on metonymy of the type PLACE → INDIVIDUAL, as we believe, then this behaviour is expected.

The exact factors governing the more flexible choice of pronoun in the institutional use are beyond the scope of this paper, but we suspect it relates to picking out a single entity or the entire set of entities for agreement.

2.8 Summary

Impersonal *everywhere* differs from institutional *everywhere* in several respects. The institutional use denotes a place-associated entity (a shop, authority, university, etc.) via metonymy and does not require an overt restrictor. The impersonal use, by contrast, quantifies over generic individuals at a location, requires an overt PP restrictor denoting a large geographic domain, and is restricted to subject position. Table 1 summarizes the properties established in this section. This overall picture is consistent with a diachronic view, developed in Section 5, according to which the impersonal use evolved from the institutional one.

With this grammatical profile established, Section 3 experimentally validates the core constraints of the impersonal construction, specifically the mandatory overt restrictor and its subjecthood requirements.

3 EXPERIMENT: IMPERSONAL ARGUMENTS AND EVERYWHERE

This section covers the basics of our experiment, an online acceptability study. The study was piloted and preregistered. Our data files and the analysis script are available in an OSF

	Institutional	Impersonal
Available reading	institution	individual
Restrictor	optional	required
PP restrictor	✓	✓
Restrictor size	any	large
Relative clause restrictor	✓	✗
Bound pronouns	<i>its/their</i>	<i>their</i>
Subject	✓	✓
Object	✗	✗

Table 1: Differences between institutional and impersonal *everywhere*.

repository. The experiment was based on attested data from corpora and the internet, our preregistration, and preliminary introspection by the first author (whose idiolect and that of their peers contains this variant).

We aimed to test the following hypotheses, H1-H3:

- H1 Speakers of English can use *everywhere* as a subject with a meaning similar to ‘everyone’.
- H2 Speakers require an overt “restrictor” for this construction to be acceptable.
- H3 Younger speakers are more accepting of this construction, and might be able to use it without the overt restrictor.

As discussed in Section 2, the range of factors governing the distribution of *everywhere* is substantial. As a first step in investigating them more systematically, we selected a certain kind of restrictor and a certain family of syntactic environments. In order to understand what kind of element *everywhere* is, we probed its syntactic and semantic properties as reflected in its acceptability in different linguistic contexts. We checked whether it is most like a full noun phrase (regular DP, synonymous with *everyone*), a frozen lexical form, or an implicit argument that is not fully nominal.

This theoretical grounding was provided by existing work on non-canonical arguments which supplies a range of diagnostics teasing apart different kinds of nominal elements. For example, the implied agent in a passive clause might be more syntactically substantiated in one language, and less so in another. Likewise, the semantic and syntactic properties of impersonal arguments cross-linguistically can also vary in the same way. The exact diagnostics used will be established as we go, in Section 3.5. We draw on Landau (2010a), who suggests ways to distinguish between “strong” and “weak” implicit arguments empirically as well as theoretically; on Legate (2014), who discusses the syntactic features that might be relevant; on the individual works cited in what follows; and on the general overview by Bhatt and Pancheva (2017). For the purposes of this study, we do not attempt to distinguish if [*everywhere* + PP] is acting alone as the syntactic and coerced logical subject, or if the structure in fact licenses some kind of covert argument in the syntax, given the scope of this paper and the charged nature of such claims. However, if the observations by Brody (2013) are correct that a locative PP can license an implicit “people” argument in the semantics, it may be enough to say that the complex PP structure comes to be associated with an implicit generic reading in the semantics, and the nominal status of *everywhere* is enough to satisfy English’s requirement for DP/NP subject. We leave the

exact analysis of the syntactic and semantic processes at play in the synchronic grammar for future work.

To preview what these diagnostics look like, the use of the agent-oriented adverb *enthusiastically* diagnoses the existence of an implicit agent in the passive construction (34a), but not in the anticausative construction (34b). We ask whether clauses with impersonal *everywhere* are more like the former or the latter.

- (34) (a) The ship was sunk enthusiastically.
 (b) * The ship sank enthusiastically. (Roeper 1987)

Some of the diagnostics are meant to probe the syntactic “size” and compositional makeup of *everywhere*, while others test its interaction with other elements in the clause (e.g. control and binding). Since we use a range of diagnostics, we introduce them as they come up. These diagnostics or tests will also be referred to as Contexts, in the sense of an experimental factor, in what follows. Each Context was also tested with standard *everyone*, which was predicted to receive very high ratings throughout.

3.1 Materials

The experiment was run in two versions, a UK one and a US/Canadian one, which differed minimally from one another.

Items were constructed by crossing three conditions: $\pm$ Where (*everywhere* vs *everyone*), $\pm$ Restrictor and Context (the syntactic and semantic diagnostics). Two lists were created, such that Where and Restrictor were counterbalanced per item.

The 10 levels of Context were spread across 20 items. For example, the level Adverb consisted of three different items (lexicalizations, or variants on the same diagnostic).

Aside from our critical items and fillers, the experiment also contained examples which were undoubtedly grammatical and examples which were undoubtedly ungrammatical; these were treated as control conditions. Six gold standard control items were added as fillers, consisting of three grammatical and three ungrammatical examples with *everywhere* (two items) and *nowhere* (one item). For each Context, we tested whether the ratings diverged from the ratings provided for the ungrammatical control examples. For each example we created one version with a restrictor and one without; a given participant only saw one of the two versions.

In total, the 2x2x10 design ($\pm$ Restrictor, $\pm$ Where, and 10 levels of Context) with six controls resulted in two lists of 46 trials each.

3.1.1 $\pm$ Where

In order to contrast impersonal *everywhere* with standard impersonal *everyone*. The expectation was that the $-$ Where variant would be at ceiling across condition, with the $+$ Where variant dispreferred in comparison given that it is substandard. The basic contrast looks as in (35), ignoring whether an overt Restrictor was given or not.

- (35) (a) Everyone (on the coast) eats fish and chips. [-Where]
 (b) Everywhere (on the coast) eats fish and chips. [+Where]

3.1.2 $\pm$ Restrictor

The Restrictor condition contrasted usage of bare *everywhere* (36a) with that of *everywhere* combined with an overt “restrictor” (36b). The basic contrast looks as in (36), ignoring the value of $\pm$ Where.

- (36) (a) Everywhere/Everyone eats fish and chips. [–Restrictor]
 (b) Everywhere/Everyone on the coast eats fish and chips. [+Restrictor]

3.1.3 Context

The last condition, Context, spanned ten different syntactic and semantic contexts meant to probe the grammatical behavior of *everywhere* (Williams 1987, Koenig and Mauner 2000, Williams 2015, Bhatt and Pancheva 2017). The first set of contexts contained simple transitive constructions, agent-oriented adverbs (following the literature discussed earlier), and different kinds of modal constructions. The next set of contexts examined whether *everywhere* was a frozen construction or decomposable to *every+where*. The third set of contexts tested whether *everywhere* behaves like a full DP in that it can antecede a pronoun; bind a possessive, reflexive or reciprocal pronoun; and control. The last set tested subjects which are not typical agents or causers, namely undergoers of psych-predicates, and subjects of passive and unaccusative verbs (both motion and change of state).

3.2 Participants

Participants were recruited from three regions. Since our initial hypothesis was that this feature was unique to the variety of English spoken along the Solent in southern England (around Southampton and Portsmouth), we recruited speakers from this area via social networks and word of mouth. All participants volunteered their time. A control group was created by recruiting speakers from other parts of the UK on Prolific, who were paid £1.5 for participation. As it became clear that there was little difference between the UK groups, we sampled a smaller control group of US and Canadian participants on Prolific, who were likewise paid £1.5 for participation.¹¹

Demographic information was collected for participants’ age, gender, level of education and geographical region.

The participants were native speakers of English from the UK, USA and Canada. The total number of participants after exclusions was 407 (261 female). Table 2 provides a breakdown of speakers by region, sex and age after exclusions.

3.3 Procedure

Our study was an acceptability rating task, carried out online. Sentences were presented with specific contexts to facilitate comprehension and were rated by participants, one sentence at a time, on a 7-point Likert scale. The leftmost radio button was labeled “least acceptable” and the rightmost one “most acceptable”. Materials were presented visually

¹¹We also conducted an analysis which left out all Solent participants, leaving 115 General UK participants (71 female, 44 male; age breakdown 18–29: 17, 30–49: 55, 50–69: 27, 70+: 16) and the 68 North American participants. The results can be found in the online repository and are qualitatively similar to what we detail below based on a larger UK sample size.

Table 2: *Final Ns after exclusions.*

		General UK 339	US/Canada 68
Gender	Female	224	37
	Male	115	25
	Other / N/A	0	6
Age	18–29	35	31
	30–49	122	21
	50–69	145	16
	70+	37	0

using PCIBex (Zehr and Schwarz 2018). Three practice trials preceded the main experiment, in which the order of trials was randomized.

3.4 Analysis

Responses were fed to an ordinal Bayesian regression model for statistical analysis (Bürkner 2017). It is generally agreed that participants do not always use the entire scale in a rating task, and furthermore do not use the scale consistently; that is to say, for a given participant, the threshold for going from 1 to 2 might be greater than from 5 to 6. Ordinal models take such inconsistencies into account and allow for more reliable analysis (White et al. 2018, Veríssimo 2021).

To exclude participants, we z-transformed responses into a continuous variable. Participants were removed from analysis if their responses on the gold standard items were, on average, more than 2 standard deviations away from the mean ratings across all participants.

The levels of Context were compared the gold standard grammatical and ungrammatical examples, as well as to each other in post-hoc analyses. Age, gender and level of education were added (separately) as covariates. Age and level of education were Helmert coded, such that each group was compared to the mean of the following ones (e.g. 18–29 vs. all older, or undergraduate education vs. all more advanced degrees).

3.5 Results

We will next see support for the following generalisations:

(37) Main findings

- (a) Overt restrictor: with an overt restrictor, *everywhere* patterns like a regular noun phrase (DP).
- (b) No restrictor: without a restrictor, *everywhere* is much less acceptable across the board. The standard *everyone* does not have this requirement, as would be expected.
- (c) Younger speakers: participants aged 18-29 are more accepting of most uses of *everywhere* (with and without Restrictor).
- (d) Region: participants from the UK rate examples with *everywhere* higher than participants from North America.

Our findings are presented using traditional acceptability diacritics for ease of exposition, which we base on the quantitative findings. Recall that each condition was contrasted with an ungrammatical control condition, and with a variant that had or didn't have a restrictor. Bayesian models do not provide t-scores and p-values, but direct estimates of effects. A 95% Credible Interval (CI) gives the range of values we would predict a predictor to take 95% of the time; an estimate of 0 means no effect. For simplicity, we translate the CI into diacritics for given example pairs, giving the overall schema in Table 3. This translation into diacritics should help give an overview of the patterns, without relying on p-values.¹²

Table 3: *Judgement diacritics based on rating differences within pairs*

95% CI	Example	Diacritic	Intuitive description
Symmetric around zero	[-0.51, 0.81]	(none)	“grammatical / no contrast”
Left/right skewed	[-0.12, 1.62]	?	“contrast between matched conditions”
Does not straddle zero	[0.14, 1.93]	??	“strong contrast between matched conditions”
Overlaps with ungrammatical control		*	“ungrammatical”

Examples are usually given in pairs, where the (a) example contains a restrictor and the (b) example does not. We present only the *everywhere* results in this section unless stated otherwise. This means that all of the *everyone* examples are not discussed here; examination of those results shows that ratings are at ceiling for all conditions (except the ungrammatical control), as expected.¹³ Where examples differed slightly in lexicalizations for our UK and North American participants, the North American one is given in a footnote.

Contexts will now be discussed in groups, according to the theoretical questions they address: the controls, which establish a baseline; transitive constructions; whether *everywhere* is compositional; whether it behaves like a full DP; and whether it can be a promoted subject. Then, we turn to demographic factors.

3.5.1 Control baselines

We first establish the baselines or gold standards. The **grammatical controls** were the following three sets of sentences (each having one version with and one version without a restrictor). As expected, all received very high ratings.

- (38) I've travelled a fair bit and different countries aren't all that different.
- (a) People everywhere in the world are the same really.
 - (b) People everywhere are the same really.

¹²A previous version of this paper used frequentist analysis on z-transformed ratings, leading to stronger findings for individual contexts (but not for the demographic factors discussed further below). We assume that this difference is due in part to the added rigor of Bayesian models, and in part to the exploratory nature and limited scope of our study.

¹³The one exception is the Middle context, which is more variable. Again, see the results in the online repository.

- (39) I think I lost my phone.
 (a) I've looked everywhere in my apartment and I still can't find it.
 (b) I've looked everywhere and I still can't find it.
- (40) I lived abroad for many years,
 (a) but nowhere in the world was nicer than home.
 (b) but nowhere was nicer than home.

Plots like those in Figure 1 accompany each set of examples. The left-hand panel shows UK participants and the right-hand one shows North American participants. The normalized z-score is on the y-axis, with the mean rating for all grammatical controls indicated by the dashed green line. Mean ratings are given by the bars: (a) examples with the restrictor on the left of each panel, “+R”, and (b) examples without a restrictor on the right, “-R”. Error bars plot 95% confidence intervals. The dotted red line indicates the mean rating for the ungrammatical controls, which come next. Scatter points show individual trials, i.e. individual rated sentences, in order to give an idea of the variation.

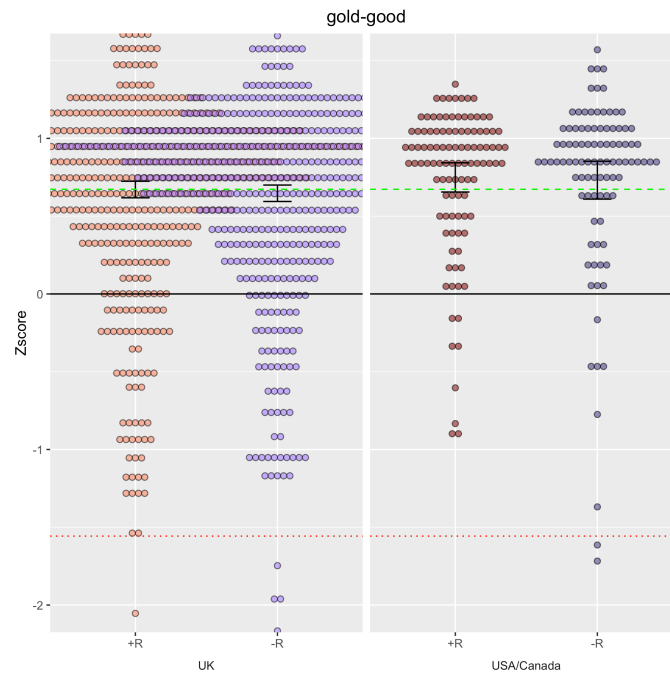


Figure 1: Grammatical controls.

Our **ungrammatical controls** were the following three sets of examples. Here ratings were very low, as expected, and accordingly all examples receive the “*” diacritic.

- (41) We were worried that John would see the photos,
 (a) * and then John the pictures everywhere in the papers saw.
 (b) * and then John the pictures everywhere saw.
- (42) We're having a gap year reunion at my place.¹⁴
 (a) * My friends at everywhere in my travels arrived last night.

¹⁴US/Canada: college reunion.

- (b) * My friends at everywhere arrived last night.
- (43) My local library contains lots of books.
- (a) * I read most of them nowhere in school.
- (b) * I read most of them nowhere.

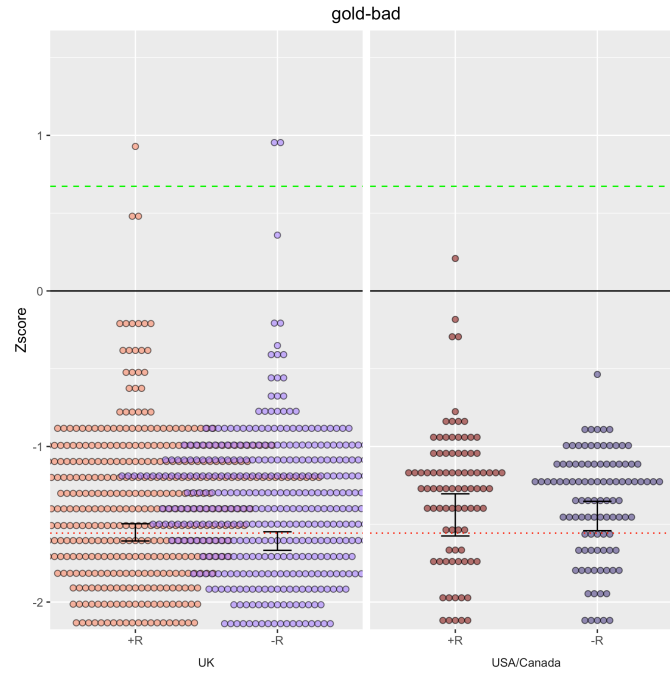


Figure 2: Ungrammatical controls.

With these baselines in place to orient ourselves, we move on to the various critical conditions. If *everywhere* is acceptable, we would expect it to be rated lower than the grammatical controls—since it is, after all, a non-standard variant—but significantly higher than the ungrammatical controls.

3.5.2 Transitive

We first tested a **simple transitive** construction in order to see if *everywhere* could be an agentive subject, comparing a transitive clause with a restrictor, (44a), with a transitive clause without a restrictor, (44b).

- (44) Is eating fish and chips¹⁵ a regional thing?
- (a) No, these days everywhere in Britain eats fish and chips!
- (b) No, these days everywhere eats fish and chips!

In Figure 3 we see that participants gave roughly similar ratings to the variants with and without a restrictor; while the mean rating for the former was slightly higher numerically, the model's estimate for the effect of the restrictor on this context (the interaction of Restrictor:ContextSimple) was in the range $[-1.12, 0.72]$, i.e. no reliable effect. We do,

¹⁵US/Canada: French fries.

however, see evidence that participants from different regions might have different intuitions, as the influence of the restrictor appears higher in the UK. We analyze the general differences between regions in Section 3.5.7.

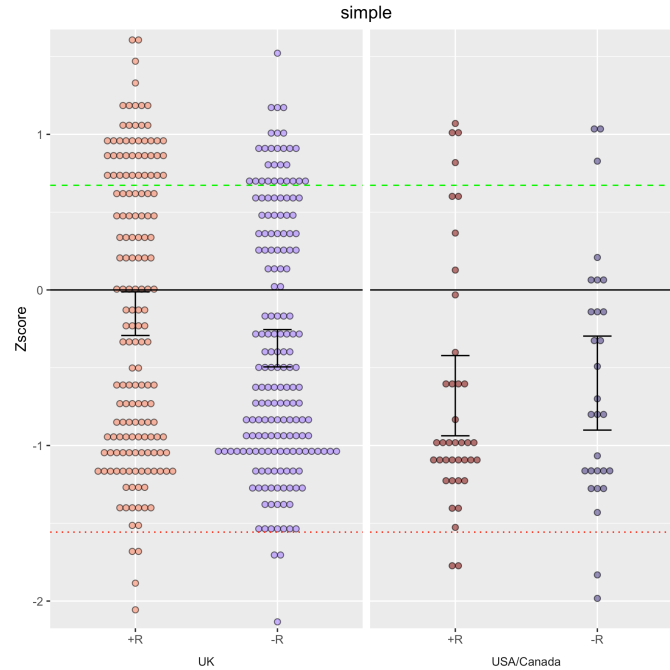


Figure 3: Simple transitives

We next tested a number of **agent-oriented adverb(ial)s** (Roeper 1987, Levin and Rapaport Hovav 1995, Landau 2010a, Alexiadou et al. 2015, Bhatt and Pancheva 2017), to verify that *everywhere* functions as an agentive subject. This expectation was borne out – within this group we include also the secondary predicates (46).¹⁶

- (45) Fighting about Brexit¹⁷ has got pretty boring.
- (a) These days everywhere in the UK is **deliberately** avoiding the subject.
 - (b) These days everywhere is **deliberately** avoiding the subject.
- (46) Legend has it that some of the best Brazilian football¹⁸ players grew up poor and didn't have money for shoes.
- (a) The FA has decided to make this a training technique, so now everywhere in England is playing football **shoe-less**.
 - (b) The FA has decided to make this a training technique, so now everywhere is playing football **shoe-less**.
- (47) When Chinese food first reached Europe, people used a knife and fork,
- (a) but everywhere in Europe eats Chinese food **using chopsticks** these days.

¹⁶Classic literature groups depictives and agent-oriented adverbs together (see, e.g., Roeper 1987) as standard agency diagnostics. However, depictives strictly require a projected DP subject/agent (Landau 2010a), whereas agent-oriented adverbs are licensed by covert agents (Alexiadou et al. 2015).

¹⁷US/Canada: the 2016 election.

¹⁸US/Canada: soccer.

- (b) but everywhere eats Chinese food **using chopsticks** these days.

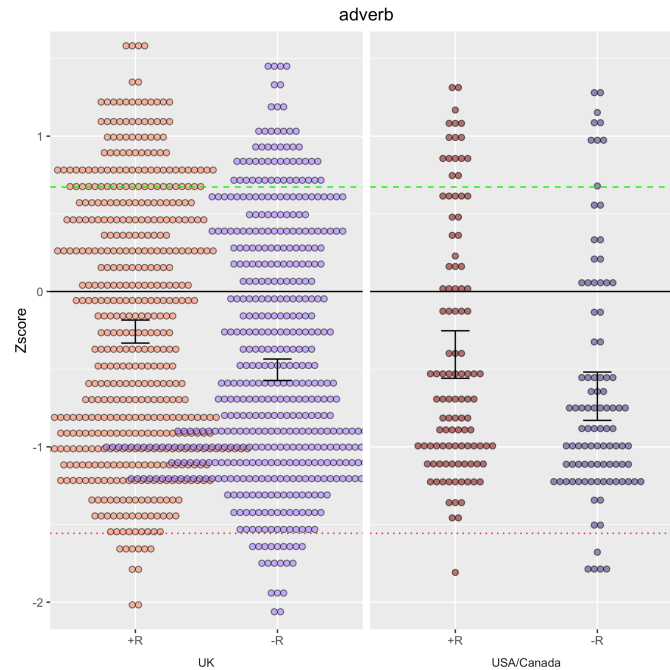


Figure 4: Adverbs.

Transitive *everywhere* is also compatible with a number of **modal and modal-like constructions**, including epistemic modals, negation and embedded questions. Such constructions have different properties than standard declarative clauses, which lead to them being less compatible with certain kinds of impersonal or implied subjects (e.g. [Bhatt and Pancheva 2017](#)). Middles were less acceptable across the board, (51), but here we saw evidence for the restrictor effect.

- (48) Even though for us it's common to have a shower daily,
 (a) not everywhere in the world **can** shower every day!
 (b) ? not everywhere **can** shower every day!
- (49) Donald Trump thought he was loved unanimously and unconditionally,
 (a) but it turned out that everywhere in America **didn't** love Trump, just a few crucial states did.
 (b) ? but it turned out that everywhere **didn't** love Trump, just a few crucial states did.
- (50) My friend told me that people abroad eat some exotic things like fried grasshoppers and bird's nest soup.
 (a) I knew about the first one, but I don't know **where** in the world eats bird's nest soup.
 (b) ? I knew about the first one, but I don't know **where** eats bird's nest soup.
- (51) Bribery doesn't just affect backward places.
 (a) ? Everywhere in the developed world **bribes easily** if the price is right.

(b) ?? Everywhere **bribes easily** if the price is right.

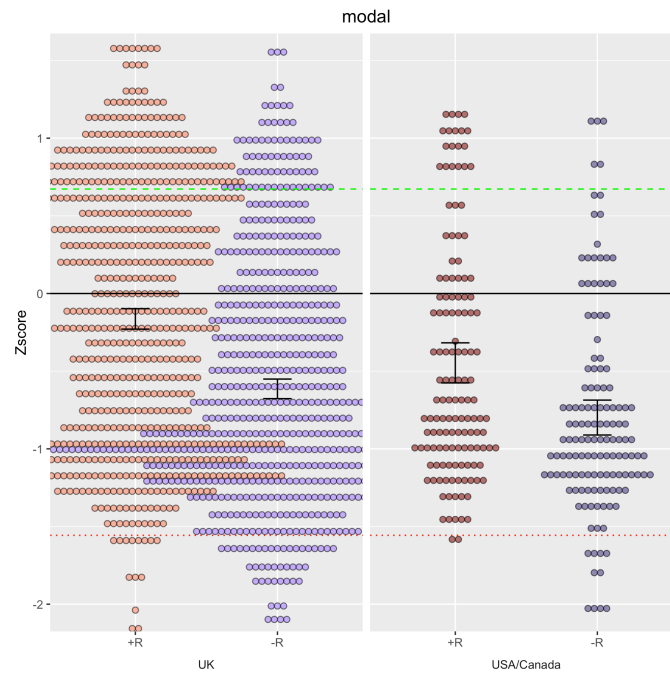


Figure 5: Modals.

So far, *everywhere* shows the behavior of a regular agentive subject, just like *everyone*, though ratings are higher when a restrictor is present in modal contexts.

3.5.3 Decomposition

The next question was whether *everywhere* is a frozen expression or whether it's compositional, consisting of *every+where*. By keeping *where* constant and changing the quantifier, we find variable acceptability across the resulting forms. This is consistent with a compositional structure in which *everywhere* decomposes into quantifier + *where*, though the ratings do not in themselves constitute proof of compositionality; rather, they show that the quantifier and the locative element make independent contributions to acceptability. This means that the type of quantification is not fixed.

Anywhere:

- (52) Most Middle Eastern religions forbid their followers from eating eagles,
 (a) but I wonder if **anywhere** in the Middle East does actually eat eagles.
 (b) but I wonder if **anywhere** does actually eat eagles.

Nowhere:

- (53) Some Royals are more popular than others.
 (a) In fact, Prince William is very popular but basically **nowhere** in the UK likes Camilla.¹⁹

¹⁹US/Canada: Prince Andrew. This data was collected in 2020.

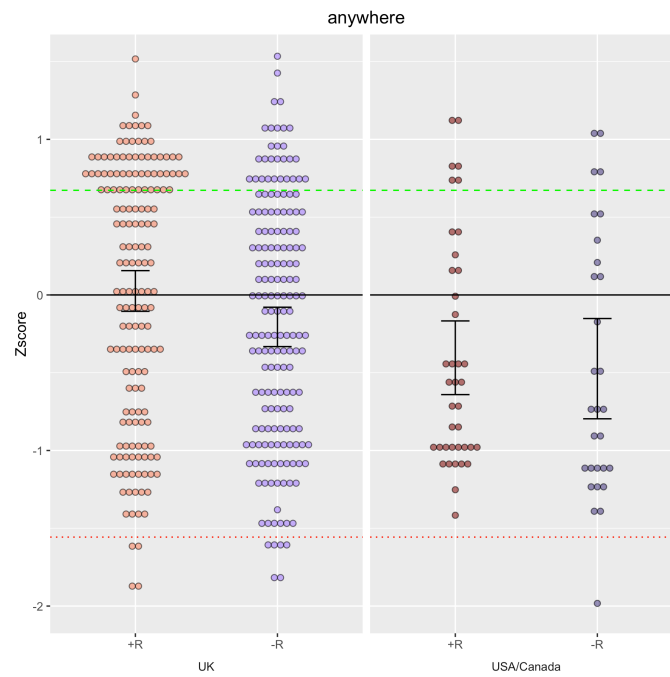


Figure 6: Anywhere.

(b) ? In fact, Prince William is very popular but basically **nowhere** likes Camilla.

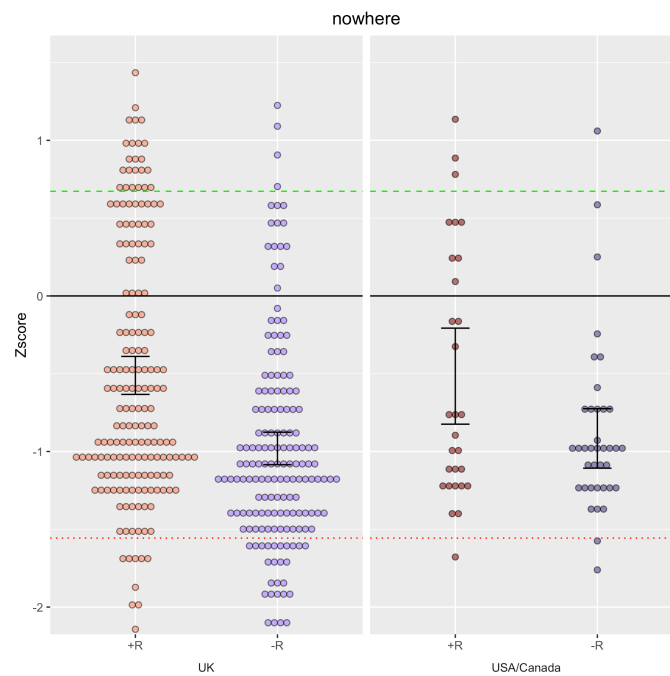


Figure 7: Nowhere.

Somewhere:

(54) People say that nobody eats cat,

- (a) but **somewhere** in the world probably does eat cat!
 (b) but **somewhere** probably does eat cat!

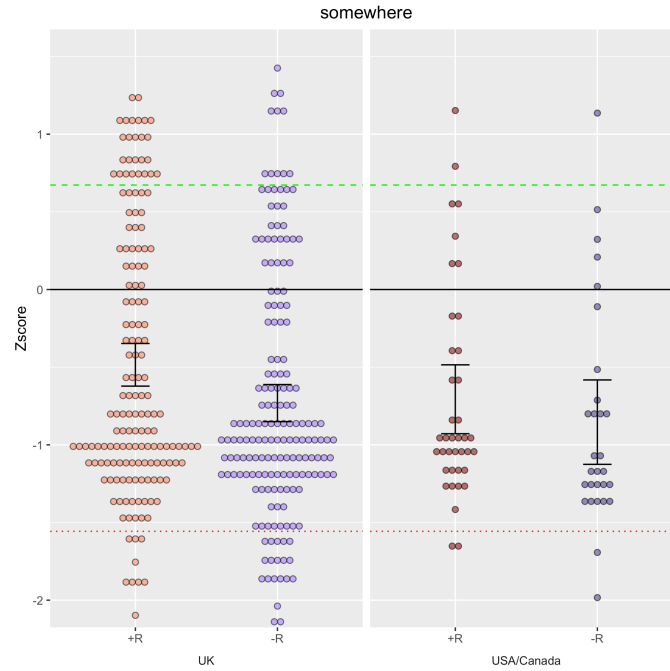


Figure 8: Somewhere

These results indicate that the *where* of *everywhere* is some kind of impersonal operator, combining compositionally with *every*, *no* and *some*.

3.5.4 Full DP

Our next set of tests probed the grammatical behavior of *everywhere*. It is commonly assumed that nominal arguments active in the syntax, i.e. full DPs, are able to **control**, rendering the control relationship a diagnostic for nominalhood (Williams 1985, Landau 2010a, Williams 2015, Bhatt and Pancheva 2017); purely semantic implicit arguments cannot behave like this. Repeating example (34) as (55), it is generally accepted that the implied agent of a passive clause is represented in the grammar at whatever level that allows it to control, whereas there is no such agent in the anticausative variant. Here, *e* signifies the silent, understood agent.

- (55) (a) The ship was e_i sunk [PRO_i to claim the insurance].
 (b) * The ship e_i sank [PRO_i to collect the insurance].

Using the canonical control predicate *try*, we find that *everywhere* can also control.

- (56) Ad campaigns against smoking have been running since the 90s.
 (a) Pretty much everywhere in the UK has been **trying** to quit since then.
 (b) ? Pretty much everywhere has been **trying** to quit since then.

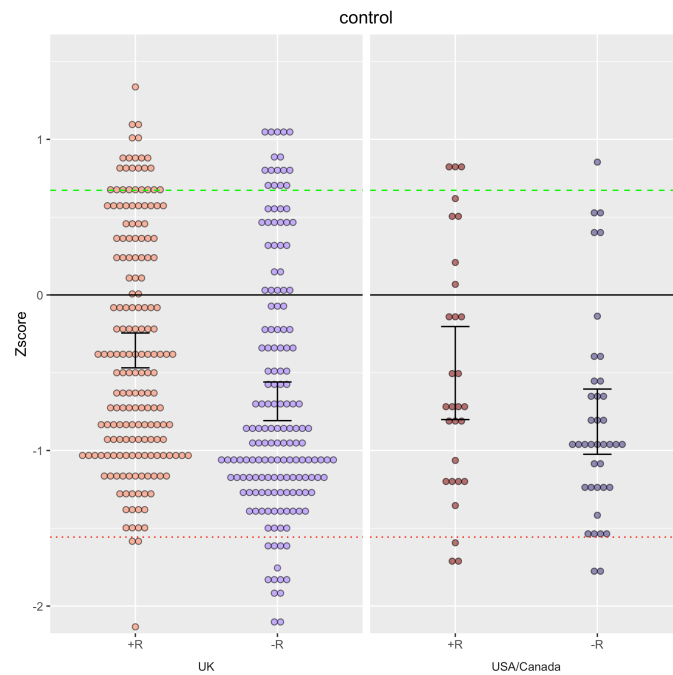


Figure 9: Control.

Full DPs can also **antecede a pronoun** (Koenig and Mauner 2000, Akkuş 2021), an option not available to many kinds of implicit arguments.

- (57) (a) A woman_i smiled. She_i was happy.
 (b) * The first male mayor_i was *e_j* assassinated. She_j was from France, it seems.
 (after Koenig and Mauner 2000:213)

We find that *everywhere* is able to antecede a pronoun:

- (58) It's not just my niece who actually says "LOL" now.
 (a) Everywhere in the UK is saying it these days! And **they** don't think it's strange.
 (b) Everywhere is saying it these days! And **they** don't think it's strange.

As discussed in depth by Williams (1987), Landau (2010a) and Bhatt and Pancheva (2017), not all impersonal or implied arguments can **bind anaphors**. *Everywhere* can bind reflexive anaphors, reciprocal anaphors and bound pronouns.

- (59) It has been revealed that people are giving less and less to charity.
 (a) It seems that everywhere in modern Britain helps **themselves** first and others later.
 (b) It seems that everywhere helps **themselves** first and others later.
 (60) There should be more sharing of resources.
 (a) That way everywhere in the country helps **each other**.
 (b) That way everywhere helps **each other**.

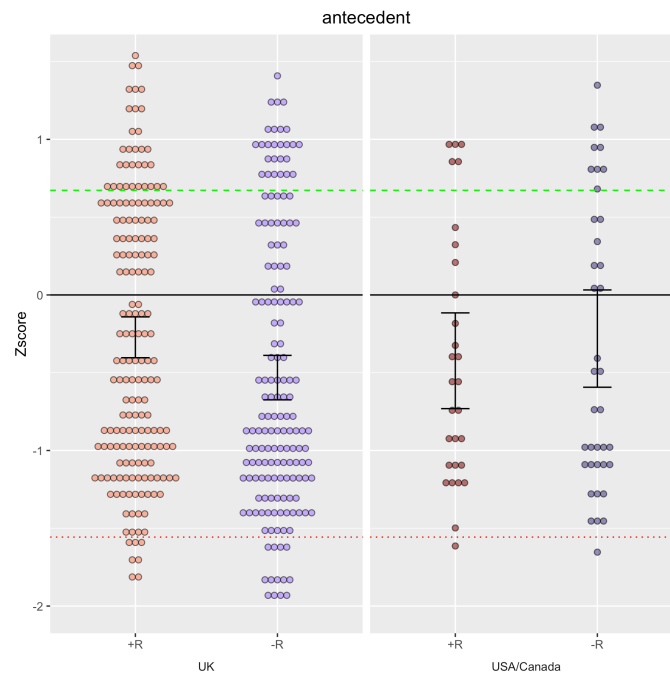


Figure 10: Antecedent.

- (61) The press has revealed that English supermarkets²⁰ have been selling dirty salad.
- (a) Now everywhere in England washes **their** salad before eating it.
 - (b) Now everywhere washes **their** salad before eating it.

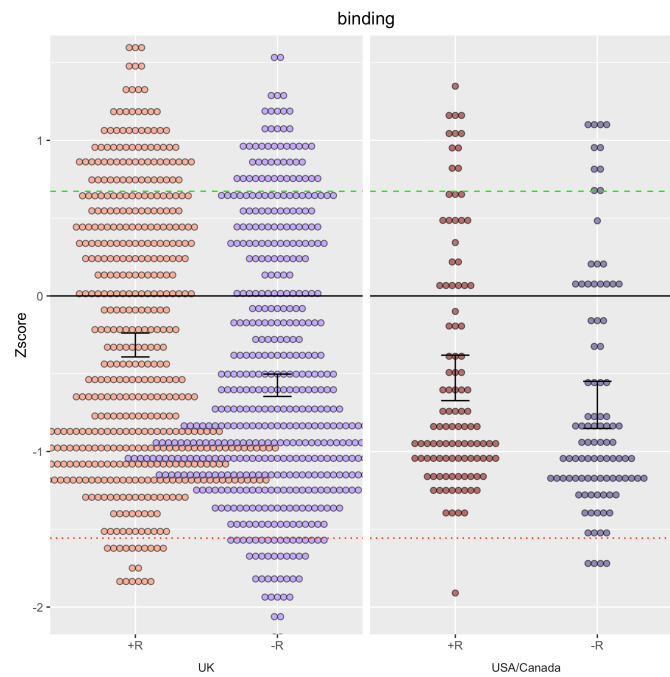


Figure 11: Binding.

²⁰US/Canada: East Coast supermarkets.

In sum, *everywhere* can control, antecede and bind like any regular noun phrase. It is a syntactically active impersonal subject.

3.5.5 Promoted subjects

The last question regarding individual Contexts has to do with the derivational history of the *everywhere* DP. It is commonly assumed that the subjects of unaccusative and passive clauses start off as the logical objects, being promoted to non-agent subjects during the derivation (however formalized in different frameworks). A similar claim is often made about psychological predicates (Belletti and Rizzi 1988, Croft 1993, Bickel 2004, Landau 2010b, Verhoeven 2014, a.m.o).

Psychological predicates are compatible with *everywhere*, especially with a restrictor:

- (62) My friend Seb wanted to see how Marmite is received abroad by taking a jar of it²¹ on his travels.
- (a) It turns out, everywhere outside of the UK **hates** Marmite.
- (b) ?? It turns out, everywhere **hates** Marmite.

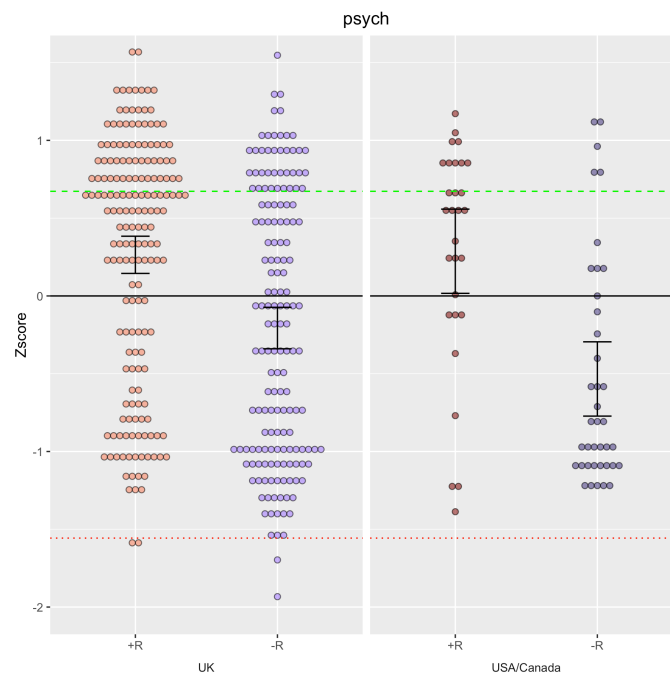


Figure 12: Psych.

Unaccusative predicates are also compatible with *everywhere*, be they directed motion as in (63) or change of state as in (64).

- (63) People always take their jobs most seriously on a Monday.
- (a) Basically everywhere in the Western world **arrives** at work bright and early on a Monday but late on a Friday!

²¹US/Canada: a bar of Hershey's.

- (b) ?? Basically everywhere **arrives** at work bright and early on a Monday but late on a Friday!

- (64) Changes in the time of the sunrise are known to influence how we sleep.
- (a) For example, everywhere in the Northern Hemisphere **wakes up** earlier in summer than in winter.
- (b) ?? For example, everywhere **wakes up** earlier in summer than in winter.

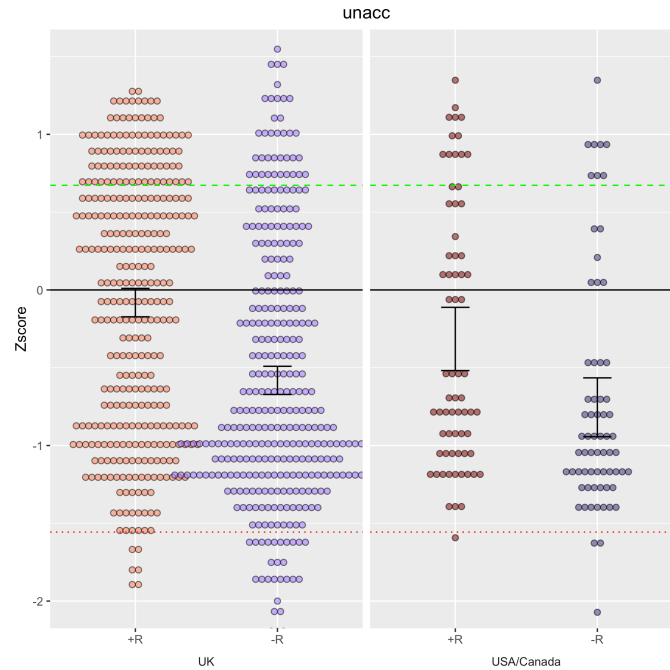


Figure 13: Unaccusative.

Our passive clause was not as compatible with *everywhere*:

- (65) The financial crisis of 2008 hit industry hard.
- (a) During the crisis, everywhere in the industrial North East was **made redundant**.²²
- (b) ? During the crisis, everywhere was **made redundant**.

This ungrammaticality of the passive is unsurprising given the discussion in 2.5; one possibility is that our passive condition was degraded as a result of being episodic, while most others were generic. Future work should test impersonal *everywhere* in both generic and episodic contexts with different types of predicate to confirm its incompatibility with the passive.

Overall, these results indicate that *everywhere* shows some but not limitless syntactic and semantic flexibility in that it may encode various semantic roles associated with subjecthood.

²²US/Canada: everywhere in the Rust Belt was laid off.

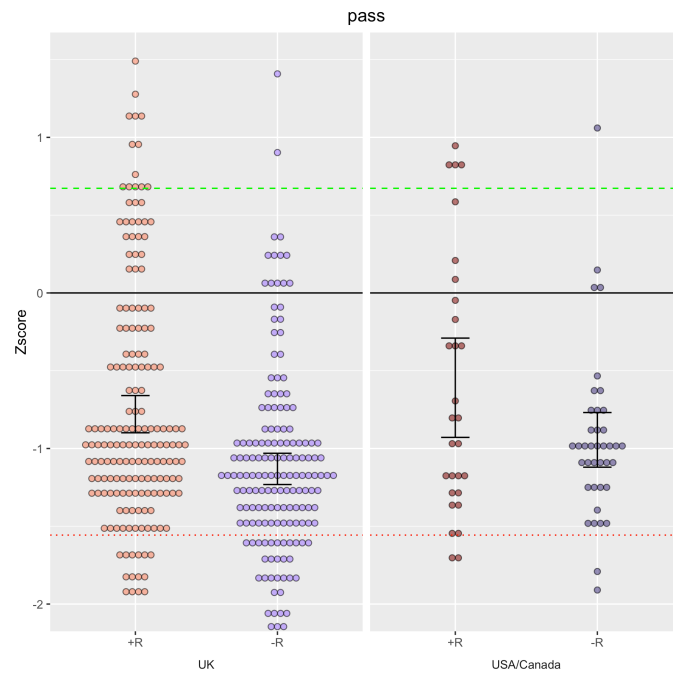


Figure 14: Passive.

3.5.6 Interim conclusion

Our findings confirm that *everywhere* is a valid impersonal subject for many speakers of contemporary English in the UK and North America. In some cases, *everywhere* is most easily accepted when the clause contains a geographical “restrictor”. Figure 15 summarizes the effect the restrictor by plotting the interaction of Restrictor and Context for each of our contexts. As discussed above, the effect is significantly above zero for at least six out of the twelve critical contexts.

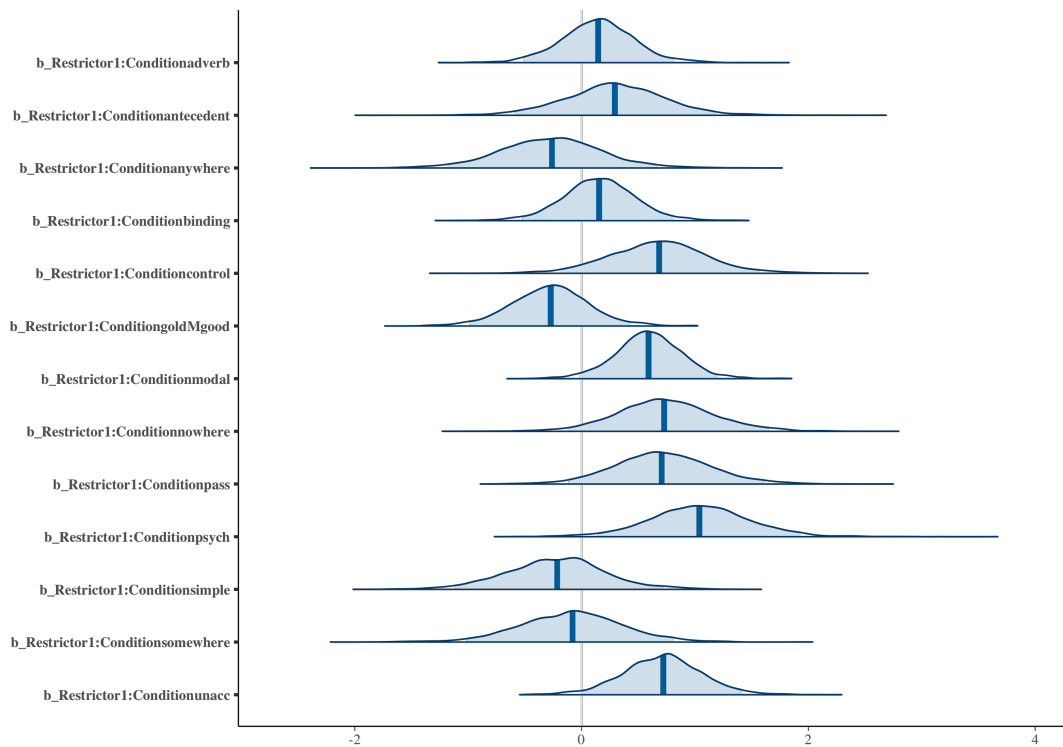


Figure 15: Posterior interactions of Restrictor and Context, with median values (thick segments) and 95% Credible Intervals (shaded areas).

The results discussed so far average over all of our participants. We now turn to an analysis based on geographical location, age and gender.

3.5.7 Demographic factors

In order to inform the study from a variationist perspective, participants were asked to provide basic demographic information after completing the experiment itself: their age (in the groups 18–29, 30–49, 50–69 and 70+), gender (where we resorted to a simplistic choice between Male, Female and Other/NA),²³ level of education and geographical location (first part of their postcode in the UK; state, province or territory in North America).

As explained in the [preregistration](#), we had originally thought that *everywhere* was a feature of a specific dialect, namely that spoken along the Solent in southern England (primarily around Southampton and Portsmouth). For this reason, we first ran a study sampling participants from that population. We then sampled from a non-Solent UK population as a control group and from North America, only to find very similar patterns. In our current discussion, we collapse both UK groups together, maintaining the comparison between UK and North America; full analyses can be found and replicated in the [OSF repository](#). Because of our original emphasis on Solent speakers, the samples are unbalanced: North American speakers are underrepresented. Issues of geographical spread are addressed in

²³While our initial reasoning was based on the premise that men and women might adopt or lead language change at different rates ([Labov 1990](#)), the design could have done a better job at targeting this question. See [Conrod \(2021\)](#).

Section 4.2. Gender and Education Level did not emerge as significant factors in any of the analyses.

3.5.8 Findings across Contexts

Finally, we report on a model which adds Age and Region as predictors, disregarding the different levels of Context (i.e. the different syntactic diagnostics). Since the oldest age group (70+) was only represented in the UK sample, it was not incorporated into this statistical model.

We find a main effect of Restrictor (CI [0.47, 0.84]) and effects of Age, in that the youngest age group (18–29, CI [−0.04, 0.27]) and the second-youngest one (30–49, CI [0.06, 0.41]) each gave higher ratings than all groups older than them. There was also a difference in Region, whereby North American participants gave lower ratings than UK participants (keeping in mind the imbalance in participant numbers), CI [−1.11, −0.36]. There were no two-way interactions, but opposite three-way interactions emerged for the North American participants’ ratings for Restrictors: 18–29 CI [−0.24, 0.04] and 30–49 CI [−0.11, 0.43]. The model’s output is given in Table 4.

Table 4: *Regression model excluding Context.*

	Estimate	Est. Error	95% CI
(Intercept[1])	−1.63	0.32	[−2.28, −1.03]
(Intercept[2])	−0.52	0.32	[−1.17, 0.08]
(Intercept[3])	0.14	0.32	[−0.51, 0.73]
(Intercept[4])	0.71	0.32	[0.07, 1.31]
(Intercept[5])	1.43	0.32	[0.78, 2.02]
(Intercept[6])	2.46	0.32	[1.80, 3.06]
Restrictor	0.65	0.09	[0.47, 0.84]
Age (18–29 vs older)	0.11	0.08	[−0.04, 0.27]
Age (30–49 vs older)	0.23	0.09	[0.06, 0.41]
Region (US/Canada)	−0.73	0.19	[−1.11, −0.36]
Restrictor:Age (18–29)	0.02	0.05	[−0.07, 0.12]
Restrictor:Age (30–49)	0.00	0.05	[−0.09, 0.09]
Restrictor:Region	−0.08	0.11	[−0.30, 0.14]
Region:Age (18–29)	−0.03	0.13	[−0.29, 0.23]
Region:Age (30–49)	0.08	0.25	[−0.41, 0.56]
Restrictor:Region:Age (18–29)	−0.12	0.08	[−0.27, 0.04]
Restrictor:Region:Age (30–49)	0.16	0.14	[−0.11, 0.43]

Summing up and summarizing all the relevant coefficients, North American participants gave lower ratings to *everywhere*, young participants gave higher ratings than older participants, and young UK participants gave slightly higher ratings than young North American participants. Having a restrictor improved ratings further for UK participants, especially young ones. Figure 16 visualizes the differences between age groups.

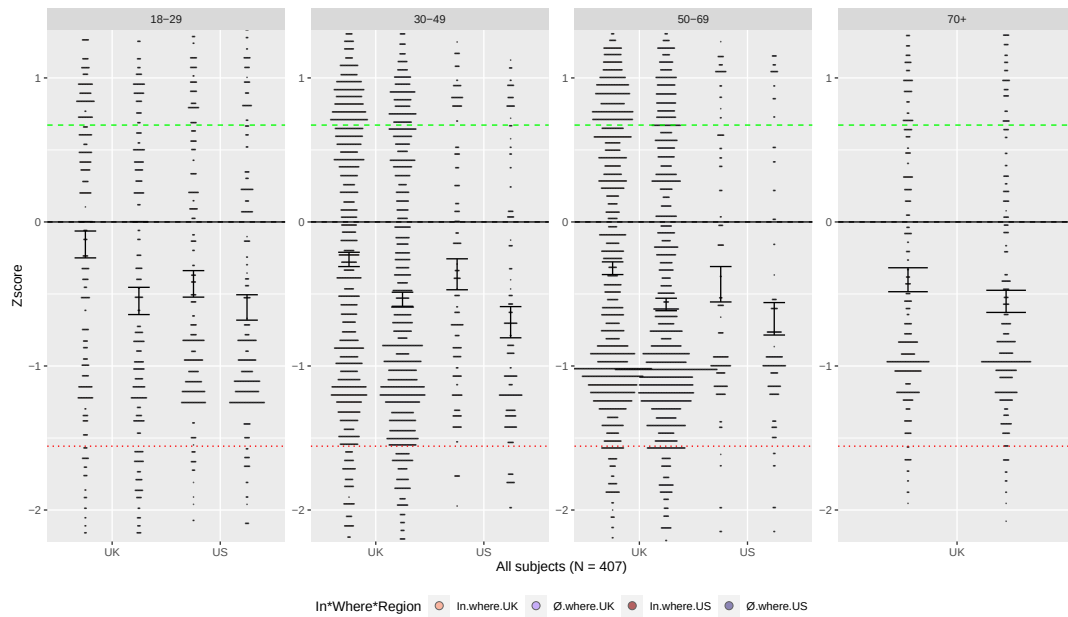


Figure 16: Age groups by region.

At this point, we believe it would be premature to investigate in more detail the effects of demographic factors on the ratings given to individual contexts. Analysis scripts can be found on OSF; we give below three examples of what interactions of Region and Age look like in our results for three contexts, namely adverb, unaccusative and control, where different effects of age could be identified.

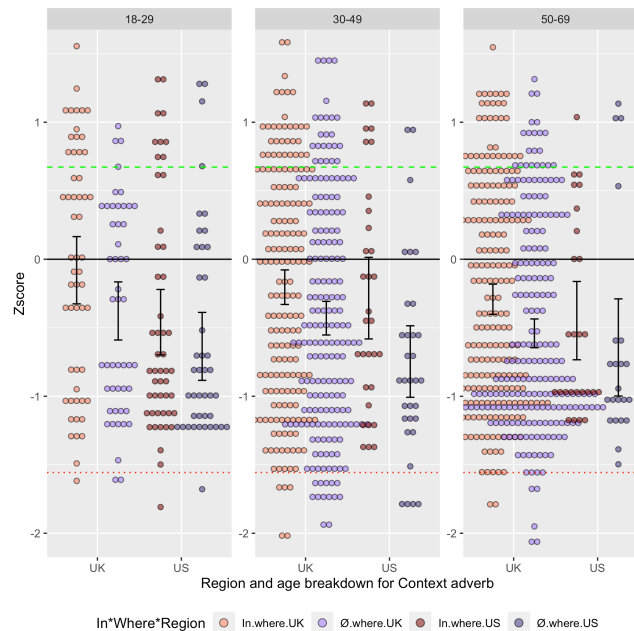


Figure 17: Region:Age interaction for Adverb.

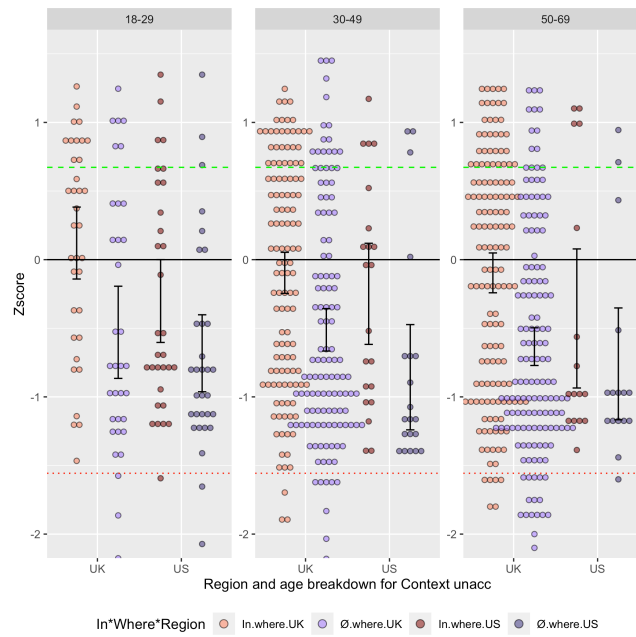


Figure 18: Region:Age interaction for Unaccusative.

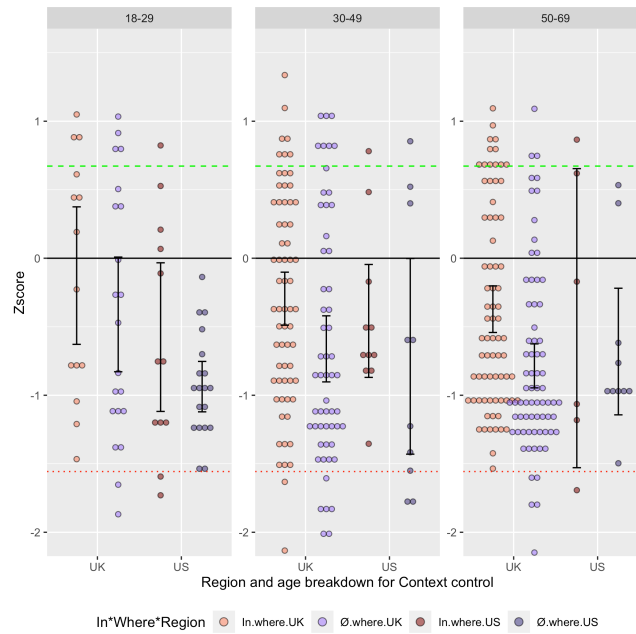


Figure 19: Region:Age interaction for Control.

3.6 Summary

While standard *everyone* is perfectly acceptable as a universally quantified subject in English, results were more varied for impersonal *everywhere*, as expected. The impersonal subject was never rated as highly as *everyone* or unrelated grammatical controls, but it was also consistently rated higher than ungrammatical controls. Moreover, the other patterns emerging from our study indicate that *everywhere* has a systematic nature of its own.

The most robust finding is that *everywhere* is rated higher when it combines with an overt restrictor, in which case it patterns like any full noun phrase. Such a requirement does not exist for standard *everyone*, of course. Younger speakers (especially aged 18–29) are more accepting of most uses of *everywhere*, especially with a restrictor, and most especially in the UK compared to North America. No effect of gender or education level was found.

In the remainder of the article, we discuss these findings from additional variationist and theoretical perspectives.

4 DISCUSSION

4.1 The syntactic findings: H1 and H2

The primary objective of the experimental study was to establish the synchronic grammatical status of impersonal *everywhere*. The results provide clear empirical confirmation for both our initial hypotheses regarding its syntactic distribution.

First, the data supports Hypothesis 1 (H1): contemporary British English speakers accept *everywhere* as a generic impersonal subject quantifying over individuals. Crucially, however, this acceptability is contingent upon our second hypothesis (H2). The experiment demonstrates that an overt locative restrictor is required for the impersonal reading. Across virtually all tested syntactic environments, including simple transitives, agent-oriented adverbs, and control structures, the absence of a PP restrictor degraded *everywhere*.

This dependency aligns with the descriptive profile established in Section 2. It confirms that the requirement for a “large” geographic domain (e.g., *in the UK*) is not merely a pragmatic preference or a feature of stylistic variation, but a structural constraint licensing the generic interpretation.

With H1 and H2 confirmed, the variable performance of *everywhere* across different demographic groups (H3) also shows consistent patterns, i.e. conditioning via age and location, to be discussed next.

4.2 Sociolinguistic Variation across British and North American Englishes

As reported, the study collected a number of demographic variables that inform us about the sociolinguistic behaviour and/or trajectory of a given variant, namely age, location, gender and education.²⁴ Coding the data for age allows us to make use of the apparent-time construct, a basic tenet of sociolinguistic analysis (Labov 1963, 1966, 1990, 1994). If such a study finds a correlation between progressively younger age groups and higher acceptability of *everywhere*, it can be taken to infer a change in progress.

In Section 3.5.7, both Age and Location emerged as strong predictors for the acceptance of [*everywhere* + PP], allowing us to evaluate Hypothesis 3 (H3). The results yield a split decision regarding H3. British English showed overall greater and incrementally increasing levels of acceptance for younger age groups, confirming the first half of the hypothesis (that younger speakers are more accepting of the variant). This age effect was less reliable in the sample of US/Canadian English speakers. However, the data decisively

²⁴The latter as a rough indicator of socio-economic status.

rejects the second half of H3: younger speakers are *not* able to use the construction without the overt restrictor. Across all demographics, the bare variant remains sharply degraded.

English is a pluricentric language with multiple standards. While some linguistic innovations come to transcend distant speech communities, perhaps via popular media or social media (e.g. Tagliamonte and Hudson 1999, Buchstaller and D'Arcy 2009), differences in behaviour of different speech communities are expected in sociolinguistic variation and change. Therefore, we now pay closer attention to each of the two samples.

4.2.1 British English

Looking first at the UK sample, the collated data by age shown in Figure 16 and the Context-specific findings such as those in Figures 17, 18 and 19 show higher ratings for younger participants. If younger people are genuinely more accepting of *everywhere* with a restrictor, then this phenomenon is an incoming variant: a change in the process of diffusing throughout the speaker population, undergoing incremental transmission from one generation to the next (see Labov 2007).

The rejection of the second half of H3 strengthens the case for a genuine grammatical innovation over a mere shift in register tolerance, i.e. the assumption that younger speakers are simply more accepting of everything. If the higher acceptability ratings among 18-to-29-year-olds were simply an artifact of younger speakers being more tolerant of highly informal and pragmatically coerced colloquialisms, we would expect them to also tolerate the bare, unrestricted variant. The fact that they require the PP restrictor indicates that this is a feature of their grammar and not just very tolerant pragmatic metonymy.

Whilst the patterning in British English may indicate a change, no effects were present for gender or education. This absence is striking given that in well-studied phonological changes, women tend to lead by up to a generation (Labov 1990, 2001, Eckert and McConnell-Ginet 2003).²⁵ However, this generalization does not straightforwardly extend to syntactic innovations, which are frequently not socially indexed in the same way (see Cheshire 2005, Tagliamonte 2011). The lack of education/class and gender effects indicates a relatively universal diffusion of the variant in British English. We consider it likely that because impersonal *everywhere* involves both a syntactic and semantic component, it is less strictly aligned with gender and class differences than changes in the phonological domain.

An alternative explanation invoking *Age-Grading* is less likely. In age-grading, an apparent generational change is in fact stable variation in the community, whereby each generation of individuals shifts its linguistic behaviour in the same way over the life span, often towards standard use in middle age (Labov 1994, 2001, Eckert 1997, Wagner 2012). This behaviour is notably associated with conscious style-shifting and correction involving variants/variables above the level of social awareness (Labov 1994:101). Yet post-hoc questioning of speakers in our study indicated a general unawareness of the generic *everywhere* construction until it was made explicit. Impersonal *everywhere* thus operates system-internally and below the level of social awareness. So while age-grading is unlikely, we may have found a so-called *change from below* in progress in the UK.

²⁵This tendency transcends types of change in that women tend to use incoming variants more frequently in both changes 'from above' involving socially salient variables or 'from below' where speakers are unaware of the variable (Labov 1990:213–218).

4.2.2 North American English

In contrast, participants from our small North American sample were less accepting of the construction. We also failed to find an age-related preference for restricted impersonal *everywhere* among the youngest North American speakers. On its own, the North American sample is not immediately indicative of a change that is actively progressing.

As it stands, we lack the data to elucidate a change scenario in more empirical detail. Given the presence of the construction in both varieties, it is possible that the innovation has simply failed to ‘get off the ground’ in the same way in North America as it has in Britain. Overall, we cannot tell at this point whether the restrictor facilitates the metonymy, resulting in reanalysis, grammaticalization, or some related process; or whether a grammaticalization (or similar) process resulted in a requirement for a restrictor. This question brings us next to discussion of how the construction might have developed.

5 DIACHRONIC TRAJECTORIES AND THEORETICAL IMPLICATIONS

Having established the synchronic grammatical profile of impersonal *everywhere* and its sociolinguistic distribution, we now turn to its emergence. The age-related patterning in the British English sample suggests that the construction is actively establishing itself within the speech community. While an apparent-time study cannot pinpoint an exact origin, the relative absence of the variant in both historical and contemporary corpora points to a recent innovation, consistent with the conservative nature of written registers.

In this section, we explore the diachronic mechanisms that facilitated the shift from a purely spatial quantifier into a generic human subject. We argue that while the innovation originates in well-attested pragmatic metonymy, its contemporary syntactic constraints indicate a formal structural reanalysis. Consequently, the change in which [*everywhere* + restrictor] has been reanalysed into a stand-alone grammatical construction is still incipient. Furthermore, it exhibits core hallmarks of reanalysis and grammaticalization (or grammatical constructionalization, Traugott and Trousdale 2013); however, we demonstrate that these characteristics are present without attempting to force the phenomenon onto an exact, traditional grammaticalization cline.

5.1 Metonymy, reanalysis, and grammaticalization

Consider first a broad definition of grammaticalization as a change in which “a lexical unit or structure assumes a grammatical function, or where a grammatical unit assumes a more grammatical function” (Heine et al. 1991:2).²⁶ Notions such as “more” or “less” grammatical are not easily defined outside of typical morphosyntactic clines such as the one in (66). Indeed, the development of *everywhere* from an indefinite locative pronoun to an impersonal pronoun is a purely syntactic change involving reanalysis from one grammaticalized functional (closed class) category to another; it is orthogonal to the grammaticalization clines.

(66) Lexical word > Grammatical word > Clitic > Affix

²⁶Several definitions of grammaticalization are available (see discussions by Heine et al. 1991, Haspelmath 1998, Harris and Campbell 1995, Campbell 2000, Hopper and Traugott 2003, Roberts and Roussou 2003, Lehmann 2015, among others), not all of which are mutually compatible.

The fact that the source material is already functional overlaps with so-called *secondary grammaticalization*, the grammaticalization of functional material from other functional material (Givón 1991, Closs Traugott 2002); but then again, secondary grammaticalization is not the most appropriate term either (regardless of how it is formulated, e.g. Breban 2015).

We suggest in what follows that *everywhere* shows some reductive properties associated with grammaticalization, namely loss of syntactic freedom and a level of semantic bleaching. On the other hand, *everywhere* also shows syntactic and semantic *expansion* (Himmelmann 2004, Traugott and Trousdale 2010b, 2013). These facts make it difficult to treat *everywhere* as a case of typical grammaticalization, posing challenges for theories of language change.

5.1.1 Metonymy as a driver of change

We have already established that both the institutional and the impersonal uses of *everywhere* are related to two different types of metonymy by which one linguistic unit may stand in for another, i.e., X FOR Y (Radden and Kövecses 1999, Littlemore 2017). The impersonal use of *everywhere* appears linked to metonymic coercion of restricted *everywhere* from a place to a stand-in for its inhabitants. Such metonymic coercion of typical NPs denoting place names is commonplace. What is remarkable in the case of *everywhere* is that an indefinite pronoun consisting of a quantifier and a WH-word can also behave in this way. Indeed, the category of *where* is not immediately clear; it has properties akin to nouns, locative pronouns, and adverbs. An innovation will have involved speakers reanalysing metonymic use of the restricted construction *everywhere* as a single grammatical syntagm. This lends support to and draws on a well-established relationship between metonymy and a range of grammaticalization phenomena (e.g. Hopper and Traugott 2003:87–93).²⁷ In this sense, some reanalysis-driven rebracketing appears to have taken place, as in (67) (cf. Harris and Campbell 1995); that is, incorporation of two adjacent yet syntactically independent phrases into a single larger structure.

- (67) (a) [Everywhere] [PP in Britain]
 (b) [Everywhere [PP in Britain]]

5.1.2 Loss of syntactic freedom

A tell-tale sign of grammaticalization is a loss of syntactic freedom (Lehmann's 2015 [1995] "syntagmatic variability"). As reported in Section 2.5, we see just this for *everywhere* in its generic individual use, which can be a subject but not a direct object. This loss of syntactic freedom associated with development into an impersonal subject opens the door to a possible diachronic explanation for why promoted subjects in passives and *by*-phrases were resistant to the impersonal reading, as shown in Sections 3.5.5 and 2.5.

²⁷We remain agnostic on the exact causal relationship between metonymy and grammaticalization, yet there is little doubt that semantic changes and competing possible analyses can feed morphosyntactic changes.

5.1.3 Semantic bleaching and expansion

Moving on, a further and straightforward similarity to grammaticalization is semantic bleaching of *-where* in the individual use (Sweetser 1988, Heine 2003, Hopper and Traugott 2003, Lehmann 2015).²⁸ While *where* canonically refers to places, in the observed use it does not. Instead, *-where* requires support from an overt locative PP; this suggests that some locative content has been retained yet it is not realized overtly, i.e. it has gone from an exponent to a requirement. This means that *everywhere* has not been totally bleached.

Simultaneously, *-where* appears to have gained both new semantic and syntactic content; *expansion* in the sense of Himmelmann (2004). On the semantic side, *-where* now refers to individuals. *Everywhere* has also expanded to serve a new syntactic function as an impersonal and has gained new semantic properties in a requirement for a “large” geographic locative restrictor. This expansion appears tied to a metonymic process of synchronic coercion which facilitated the reanalysis of an indefinite locative pronoun to an individual generic subject construction with both a [+human] and secondary locative content.²⁹ Given the established relationship with metonymy in both synchronic and diachronic terms, we can view the newer [+human, +individual] properties of *-where* as the result of novel semanticization of the inference made via metonymy, in this particular context contributing to a new layered use of *everywhere*. From both a syntactic and semantic (and perhaps also pragmatic) perspective, *-where* has gained selectional properties of requiring not only a locative PP, but also one that is “large” enough in terms of the location size. Since *everywhere* is compatible with a range of locative preposition, e.g. *at*, *in*, *on*, other reductive morphological or phonological processes associated with later-stage grammaticalization phenomena (Heine et al. 1991, Heine 2003, Hopper and Traugott 2003, Lehmann 2015) remain absent. From a Construction Grammar perspective, such change could be classified as “Grammatical Constructionalization”.

Formal-generative approaches would also need to reconsider their assumptions. Usually in such approaches, grammaticalization is considered to be reanalysis up or down hierarchical clause structure (e.g. Roberts and Roussou 2003, van Gelderen 2018). This is not obviously the case for impersonal *everywhere*.

In sum, we have shown that the restricted generic individual use of *everywhere* not only appears to be advancing in British English, but that its grammatical behaviour shows certain characteristics typical of grammaticalization-related phenomena in terms of both reduction and expansion, which following Traugott and Trousdale (2010a:3) need not be in opposition but rather refer to complementary processes affecting changes in morphosyntactic form, on the one hand, and changes in function on the other. Clearly, the latter is most relevant for the case of *everywhere*.

5.2 Theoretical implications

Overall, we consider *everywhere* an incipient generic impersonal structure which appears to be undergoing gradual intergenerational transmission (see Labov 2007) below the level of individual sociolinguistic awareness, in at least British English.

²⁸Semantic bleaching is also known as semantic reduction, semantic weakening (Heine 2003, Hopper and Traugott 2003), and desemanticization (Lehmann 2015).

²⁹We take reanalysis to be a necessary step in any grammaticalization process (Campbell 2000, but see Haspelmath 1998).

We interpret the incrementally higher acceptability ratings of impersonal *everywhere* among younger UK speakers as a change in progress. The [*everywhere* + PP_{LOCATIVE}] construction exhibits some core grammaticalization properties: loss of syntactic freedom, partial semantic bleaching, and syntactic expansion. However, *everywhere* does not appear to sit on a classic grammaticalization cline, since its simultaneous reductive and expanding properties challenge traditional grammaticalization frameworks.

We are still left with the question as to why the overt locative restrictor is mandatory and what the exact process was by which it emerged. In pure synchronic metonymy, we might expect that context in the Common Ground could bypass the need for the PP, but this does not appear to be the case. We acknowledge that diachronic linguistics is a theoretically heterogeneous pursuit; hence, we briefly provide outlines of a formal generative and usage based proposal for the emergence of *everywhere*. We do not commit to a single theoretical framework, but offer these preliminary proposals as a foundation for future theoretical debate.

5.2.1 A tentative usage-based proposal

Firstly, the structural reanalysis of *everywhere* can be formalized as the emergence of a [*everywhere* + PP_{LOCATIVE}] template via grammatical constructionalization (Traugott and Trousdale 2013). As noted by an anonymous reviewer, this development aligns cleanly with grammatical constructionalization. Here, the reanalysis of a novel constructional template would map directly onto a generic human subject; the generalization on the generic impersonal licensing behaviour of locative PPs by Brody (2013) holds as a potential trigger or facilitating factor, even if the formalisation of these effects is modelled differently. A working hypothesis under such an approach is that metonymy is the primary driver of such an interpretation before reanalysis is complete. Constructionalization also naturally captures both the mandatory overt restrictor and the metonymic shift without requiring silent or complex syntactic architecture.

5.2.2 A tentative generative proposal

Conversely, a formal generative model could view impersonal *everywhere* as the product of reanalysis-driven syntactic rebracketing (see Harris and Campbell 1995). Under this view, the locative PP does more than delimit a spatial domain; it introduces a structurally active, covert [PEOPLE] argument (akin to the mechanics proposed for impersonal *they* by Brody 2013). Interpreting the apparent-time data as evidence of an active change implies that the syntactic and semantic behaviour of generic *everywhere* reflects a diachronic process, rather than mere synchronic metonymic coercion. From a Minimalist perspective (Chomsky 1995), the reanalysis could entail two principal steps: i) quantified *where* acquires a strict, uninterpretable selectional feature enforcing the overt PP restrictor; and ii) the resulting syntactic dependency binds the quantifier to the implicit generic [PEOPLE] argument licensed by the locative PP. Because *everywhere* has quantificational and thus DP-like qualities, it is free to act as a DP subject of the clause and its strict association with the PP provides the generic and semantic content needed for the structure to pass all interface conditions, which explains the subject-like properties observed in our data. The interpretation of the implicit people argument could furthermore be interpreted as a

relational noun, denoting a 2-place relation between a person and a location, giving rise to the reading of divisible inhabitants of locations.

We leave further detailed formalization of both the synchronic and diachronic syntax within the respective usage-based and generative traditions to future research.

6 CONCLUSION

In this paper, indefinite locative *everywhere* was argued to be an available impersonal subject in English when restricted by a locative PP. Quantitative and qualitative findings suggest a difference between an institutional use, apparently working at the level of metonymy, and the impersonal use. While the former does not appear to show semantic and syntactic restrictions on its use, the impersonal use was shown to stand out in that a generic individual reading is only available when *everywhere* is (a) restricted by a large geographic locative PP, and (b) acts simultaneously as the semantic and syntactic subject. We have not attempted a full formal analysis, yet future theoretical work should aim to better understand the syntactic and semantic mechanisms at hand.

From a diachronic and variationist perspective, the apparent-time construct showed increased acceptance among younger generations of impersonal *everywhere* for speakers from the UK, perhaps indicating a change in progress. Notably, this was not the situation for our small sample of participants from North America. We suggested that the UK data shows how the impersonal use has gone beyond metonymic coercion from PLACE → INDIVIDUALS, and has developed into a fully fledged impersonal. If correct, these proposals fit into a well-known link between metonymy and phenomena related to grammaticalization, reanalysis, and processes of change.

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